

CHAPTER V

Protestant Christologies in the Twentieth Century

1. Crisis Theology

The first decades of the 20th century signaled the end of liberal Protestant

theology. Its various forms were radically opposed to the beliefs of the rank and file church members and confused rather than enlightened the Christian faith of those studying for the ministry. Moreover, the barbaric sufferings the civilized nations of Europe inflicted upon each other in World War I had suddenly brought to light the human capacity for evil. The naive faith of the Enlightenment in unlimited moral progress through mere human efforts, a faith that had deeply influenced liberal Protestantism, was suddenly shaken to its foundations. The Jesus of liberal Protestantism who was ultimately only a human being and provided only an example of moral living, but did not redeem us from

our fallen human condition, proved suddenly irrelevant.

Karl Barth, a young Swiss pastor who was himself raised in the liberal tradition, soon realized that his academic training did not prepare him for the job of preaching God's Word to his congregation. In order to help himself and other pastors in a similar position, he published a commentary on the Letter to the Romans in 1918. He was surprised by both the tumultuous welcome and the controversy that ensued. When later reflecting on what happened, Barth compared himself to a man who, climbing up a church steeple in the middle of the night, and reaching out for support, accidentally seized the bell rope and woke up the whole city.²¹² Barth was not alone in

his endeavor to return to the Word of God in the Bible and to the insights of the great reformers, Luther and Calvin. Rudolph Bultmann, Emil Brunner, Paul Tillich, to mention only the greatest names, shared his concern. For some years, they together constituted a recognizable new trend, that of "crisis theology."

"Crisis" in this context means God's judgment upon the human being. God is experienced as the Holy One, and because of his holiness, he appears as the wholly Other to sinful humanity. God's Word for us cannot be anything but judgment, a condemning no to all that is human. The distance and opposition between God and unredeemed humanity is perceived to be absolute. Such a view excludes the

possibility of the incarnation. For crisis theology the divine dignity of Christ does not imply an ontological truth. It only means that God's definitive, eschatological Word comes to us through Christ, and it is through this Word that we are both condemned and saved.

Each of the "crisis" theologians developed later in his own personal direction, even distancing himself (to one degree or another) from the initial program. I will here outline only the Christologies of Bultmann, Barth, and Bonhoeffer, who is perhaps Barth's most original disciple.

2. Rudolph Bultmann

Bultmann's fundamental goal is to pre-

sent to his age the authentic Christian message purified from its liberal distortions. Yet in his philosophical presuppositions and in his method he is strongly determined by the liberal heritage. On the one hand, in reaction against Schleiermacher, Bultmann emphasizes that the transcendent Word of God cannot be reduced to a datum of religious consciousness. On the other hand, accepting the conclusions of the school of the history of religions (W. Bousset and W. Heitmüller), he sees the world view and the language of the New Testament as entirely mythological: The pre-existent Son of God was born of a Virgin by a miraculous divine intervention. He sacrificed himself on the cross, thereby placating God's wrath by shedding his own

blood for the sins of a fallen humanity. Rising from the dead, he conquered the demonic powers and death, ascended into heaven and is soon to come, to judge the world in an apocalyptic catastrophe. Then the redeemed human being will be transferred into a celestial realm and endowed with a spiritual body.²¹³ According to Bultmann, all the major elements of this story were borrowed from Jewish apocalyptic and Gnostic redemption myths, and in this mythological form they remain completely incredible to the modern reader.²¹⁴

Bultmann does not explain very carefully what he understands by myth. It is only in one of the footnotes of his famous essay, “New Testament and Mythology,” that he gives a rather loose definition:

Mythology is the use of imagery to express the otherworldly in terms of this world and the divine in terms of human life, the other side in terms of this side. For instance, divine transcendence is expressed as spatial distance.²¹⁵

In spite of the far-reaching structural identities he sees between the New Testament story and other ancient religious mythologies, Bultmann emphasizes two important differences. First, there is a historical core behind the mythical story of the incarnate, crucified, and risen God, namely, the historical figure of Jesus of Nazareth. Second, in and through the mythical language of the New Testament the early Church proclaims her faith that in Jesus of Nazareth

God's redemptive act has taken place for all humankind. However, according to Bultmann,²¹⁶ the history of Jesus, as he lived and died, remains inaccessible for us. Only this proclamation of faith, the kerygma of the early Church about the crucified and risen Christ, is available for our age. But this is all we need, since it is in the kerygma that God's saving Word encounters us.

Nevertheless, the mythological crust prevents the people of our scientific age from hearing God's Word in the kerygma. It creates an unnecessary obstacle to faith. In our times no educated person is capable of believing in a spatially divided three-storied universe (heaven above, earth in the middle, and hell below), in the existence of angels and devils, in actual miracles, and in

a physical resurrection. For modern man, whose thinking is "shaped for good or ill by modern science," mythological language is "not only irrational but utterly meaningless."²¹⁷ Thus "demythologization," the "restatement of the event of Jesus Christ in non-mythological terms," becomes a necessary task for theology; it is not a discarding but rather an interpreting of the myth of the New Testament. Its purpose is not to destroy faith, but rather to eliminate an unnecessary stumbling block to faith for us and to facilitate our encounter with the Word of God.

But how should one interpret the New Testament non-mythologically, without distorting its meaning? Bultmann believes that a philosophical study of myth

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in general provides an initial clue for the right method of interpretation. “The real purpose of the myth is not to present an objective picture of the world as it is, but to express man’s understanding of himself in the world in which he lives.”²¹⁸ Thus the myth itself, in order to be properly understood in its original intention, calls for an existential interpretation. The same applies to the New Testament. In fact, the theologian has only to continue what the New Testament itself has already begun, namely an existential re-interpretation of the mythical event of the saving death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. For instance, St. Paul understands the death and resurrection of Jesus primarily as an existential event for and in the believer. Bultmann’s

goal is, then, to bring to completion the process of the existential re-interpretation of the New Testament with the help of the existential philosophy of the early Heidegger.

Everything in this re-interpretation centers on dying to the old life, and rising to a new life; that is, going over from the old self-understanding, which is called “life according to the flesh,” a life of slavery under the power of sin, death, and the devil in biblical terminology, to a new self-understanding, which is called “life according to the spirit” or “life in faith” in the New Testament. The first is inauthentic life, the second authentic. In the first, we cling to the securities, rewards, and achievements that this visible and tangible world

provides, but in the process one “becomes the slave of that very sphere which he had hoped to master, and which he hoped would give him security.”²¹⁹ In the second, the authentic life, we abandon all “self-contrived security.” If we possess the attitude that the New Testament calls “faith,” “the unseen, intangible reality actually confronts us as love, opening up our future and signifying not death but life.” We let all our earthly attachments go, surrender all our self-confidence and resolve to trust in God alone and accept our future from him in unconditional obedience.²²⁰

Facing his critics’ challenge on why the historical event of Jesus Christ was still important for this existential analysis, Bultmann insisted that the Heideggerian

categories serve only as a means to understand the New Testament kerygma. No philosophical analysis can bring about this new self-understanding in any human being; only God’s saving Word can, and the believer encounters this Word exclusively in the kerygma of the cross of Jesus Christ. It is the Word of Christ in the kerygma that judges one and condemns one’s inauthentic existence and gives one the power to rise to a new life. In this regard Bultmann remains an orthodox Lutheran who believes in the fall of humanity and in our inability to rise from the state of sin by our own power of will and understanding.²²¹

Bultmann’s influence can hardly be overstated. His thoughts and the opposition to his thoughts shaped a whole generation of

Protestant scholars. After Vatican II, when Bultmann's influence was already waning among Protestants, Catholics were just beginning to wake up to the challenge of his program of demythologization.

Bultmann's program is seductive, because it speaks to a real need and offers a simple solution. It is true that God's Word does indeed come to us in and through the time-conditioned language and world view of a past age, and thus we do need to distinguish what God's Word intends to reveal from the time-conditioned medium in which revelation takes place. The Bible needs to be re-interpreted in every age. However, in the process the whole of God's revelation needs to be preserved and "re-translated" rather than deformed or dis-

carded. Bultmann, in spite of his own intention, could not avoid the latter.

He is led by his Kantian epistemology to the position that the Word of God does not reveal anything, provides no deeper knowledge of God; it has no object, no content. It is merely an act that transforms one's self-understanding.²²²

Furthermore, Bultmann's definition of myth is so broad as to include the mystery of the incarnation. If myth is the expression of the otherworldly in terms of this world, then indeed the figure of the man Jesus as God in human form is a myth and needs to be discarded. It would only obscure the true message of the New Testament to call this man God or Son of God in the traditional sense of the term. Jesus is God or

Son of God only in the sense that he is the carrier of God's decisive Word addressed to man. Thus Bultmann ends up not merely re-interpreting but eliminating the Christian message.

Bultmann's program needs to be criticized not only from the theological viewpoint of the New Testament itself, but also from the viewpoint of his so-called "modern man" with a scientific world view. The educated person of today expects much less from science than Bultmann's hypothetical "modern man" did regarding a valid explanation of objective reality in general. Today we are more aware of the inherent limitations of science and more ready to admit the existence of mysterious powers beyond what is empirically

detectable.

Some of Bultmann's disciples could not live with the inconsistencies of his system. They moved away from his "heritage" in different directions. As we have seen, Käsemann became convinced that Bultmann's *a priori* injunction not to go beyond the kerygma to investigate the historical events concerning Jesus of Nazareth is historically unwarranted and theologically false. He and his group started a new quest for the historical Jesus.²²³ Others thought that Bultmann was not radical enough in demythologizing Christianity. After all, he still clung to a transcendent act of God that reaches us in the preaching of the kerygma of Jesus Christ. Speaking about an act of God is as mythological — these writers

claimed — as the rest of the New Testament language. Thus, they kept the existential analysis, but dismissed the need for the intervention of a transcendent God.²²⁴ Still others accepted the need for God's grace in order to arrive at a new self-understanding, but questioned that God's grace was necessarily connected to the kerygma of Jesus Christ.²²⁵ God's gift of love — they said — is available everywhere in human existence, not only in the kerygma.²²⁶

3. Karl Barth

The early Barth was the most radical among the “crisis theologians.” He could not stress enough the infinite distance between sinful humanity and the holy God

who confronts the sinner as the wholly Other. In losing this perspective on God, liberal Protestantism has lost, according to Barth, the very substance of faith. It reduced faith “to the highest possibility of human reason, revelation to the highest peak of human history, the God-consciousness of Jesus to the highest possibility of human religiosity.” Briefly, God came to be seen as an amplification to the infinite degree of mere human perfections. This God — Barth thought — was nothing but our own projection, and Feuerbach was right in pointing that out.²²⁷

In contrast to liberal Protestantism, the early Barth advocates such an absolute opposition between God and humanity that, in his vision, there is no potential in